

God is good

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Introduction

I'm an Enneagram 5, apparently— at least in this stage of life, career number two, which has lasted the longest. When I was a US Naval Officer, thinking about what was next for me and my family, I entertained the idea of applying for graduate school, and then I did. It worked out, and I ended up taking a job as an engineering professor afterwards. I thought I might want to be a professor before I decided to go to college, although I was thinking about math at the time.

My beautiful, smart wife said that my writing to date has been lacking a certain personal touch. It's only for an audience of fives, and probably then a particular sort. I'm sure she's right. I'll see what I can do in this book to turn the tide a bit.

I do write about things that interest me. Right now that's mainly God and the Bible, which I consider to be His inspired Word, the Holy Spirit speaking through mankind.

If it's all real, which I think it is, it's the most amazing thing that could have ever happened in the history of ever.

If it's real, which some of us might hope it is, it answers questions like, What is good? Who is good? Why do we experience good? What is the source of good?

If you'd like to think about coming on a short journey with me to consider such questions, for at least a *bit* more of your time one day, keep reading.

Bit 1: The source of good

“Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change.”

James 1:17 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jas.1.17.ESV>

What do you consider to be good in your life?

Close relationships are typically among our greatest treasures. As for me at this time in life, it's my wife and my kids especially. I've also really enjoyed relationships that were close at times, like the many I had in high school with friends and extended family.

Whom do you treasure?

Then there are the varieties of freedoms and joys that we have the opportunity to experience. As for me, I love the outdoors, especially a sunrise or sunset, and time on the water; a good meal; travel with family.

What brings you joy?

Next, there are the very good things that some of us may often forget, like good health and the energy to do the things we need to do and the things we want to do.

Are you in good health?

To many, this world we live in appears to us a mixture of good and evil, even of heaven and of hell. Relationships can be damaged or broken. Our freedoms and the things we enjoy can be taken away. Our health may suffer, or the health of our loved ones may suffer. We all experience suffering, loss and death.

Some of my family relationships are damaged. While I am not lonely, many that I've known and talked to are lonely and hurting; some of them live on the street from day to day. I spend time nearly each week with incarcerated people that no longer have the freedom to do what they would like to do, and may not have interactions with family members any more. I have people close to me that are not in good health. I also keep abreast of the status of believers in other countries that are persecuted for their Christian faith. Then there are the ongoing mass shootings here in America and the wars abroad that remind me of the evil in the world.

Do you see the world we live in as a mixture of good and evil? Or how do you see it?

What or who is the source of good?

By a decision of faith based on scriptures like the one cited above, I've come to believe that our creator God is the source of everything good. Scripture reveals that our God is good by nature, and God is the source of every good thing. Outside of God, we would not experience any good.

Scripture says that God does not bring evil our way, including temptations (James 1:13). Instead, it teaches that there is an enemy of God and of you, the devil, who has "great wrath" for you, because you are a treasured child of God, desiring to "steal, kill and destroy" what belongs to our Father (John 10:10). The devil, knowing God's law against sin and what it requires, is accusing us day and night (Revelation 12:10). The devil and those in league with him devise ways to entice us to sin, so that we may join him in open rebellion against the God who has only ever desired our good.

Do you think that the God who made you is the source of good? That He has your best interest in mind? Or do you think you are the one that needs to make sure good things come your way in life?

What do you believe about evil?

Bit 2: Why we experience good

“‘You have heard that it was said, ‘You shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy.’ But I say to you, Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven. For he makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust.”

Matthew 5:43-45 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/mat.5.43-45.ESV>

Have you ever thought that life is unfair?

When I was a child, I definitely thought this to be the case a lot. We have an inborn sense of fairness, don't we?

For me, this desire for fairness persists to this day of mid-life as well. I see inequity for our children based on the neighborhoods and schools they are in. I see people who get ahead in our world sometimes based on shaping perception rather than on what they really did. Many without good intent seem to experience a lot of good in life. Some people get away with murder, so to speak, or for real, while people who don't seem to deserve it suffer.

Oftentimes, we'd like to become the one in charge in order to see that things are fair, as we see them. Or we'd at least like a seat at the table to be able to decide on the things we feel are important.

The Bible excerpt above comes from the Sermon on the Mount, which is probably the most famous set of teachings by Jesus of Nazareth. One of the most shocking, countercultural teachings of His was that of love for enemies. This excerpt is from part of that teaching.

Jesus taught that it was God's very nature to show love to His enemies. Even today, God makes His sun rise in the evil and the good. He sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous alike.

In other words, Jesus taught that God is good to everyone.

God also makes it possible for us to experience good by way of the created law that we reap what we sow.

Why would God allow for good to come to the evil and the good?

A good parent wants the best for his or her children, no matter where they are in life.

If they are headed down a wrong road, maybe they will change.

What do you believe about God as a parent?

Bit 3: A time period for good

“And he came to Nazareth, where he had been brought up. And as was his custom, he went to the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and he stood up to read. And the scroll of the prophet Isaiah was given to him. He unrolled the scroll and found the place where it was written, “The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed, to proclaim the year of the Lord’s favor.” And he rolled up the scroll and gave it back to the attendant and sat down. And the eyes of all in the synagogue were fixed on him. And he began to say to them, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing.””
Luke 4:16-21 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/luk.4.16-21.ESV>

If God now shows love and goodness to good and bad people alike, has this always been the case? Will it always continue to be the case?

It seems unfair, right? How could we think that God is just?

The scripture excerpt above comes from Luke’s record of Jesus announcing His ministry in His hometown, Nazareth, by quoting part of a prophecy from Isaiah 61. He claimed at the gathering place of His hometown that His ministry started a new era, “the year of the Lord’s favor.” The word year really suggests a time period. Jesus’ ministry ushered in an extended time period for the display of God’s goodness, the measure of which had not been seen before, and which would not last forever.

While it’s a finite period, it’s a long one! It lasts to this day, thousands of years later.

According to Jesus, we are in a time period of good. Good comes to the righteous and the unrighteous, the good and the bad, just as He taught the passage reviewed in [Bit 2](#) (Matthew 5:43-45).

For followers of Christ, good also comes to us through the same Holy Spirit that anointed Jesus Christ for ministry. In this time following Jesus’ ascension, the Holy Spirit anoints each obedient minister of Jesus Christ (Acts 2:39, 5:32). The Spirit of the Lord on Jesus proclaimed good news to the poor. Now, Christ living in us still proclaims good news to the poor. In Jesus’ ministry on earth, the Spirit in Him proclaimed liberty and brought liberty to masses of people. The Spirit still does that today through obedient followers of Christ, bringing good to many throughout the world.

Christ’s ministry was summarized by the Apostle Peter in this way: “...God anointed Jesus Christ of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good...” (Acts 10:38). The Apostle John described His ministry this way: “The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil.” (1 John 3:8b). The church (comprised of obedient Christ followers) continues this ministry of doing good and destroying the works of the devil as His

ambassadors, or as His living, functioning body in the world! The good that that we do can even leave a legacy of good for generations.

After Christ's empowerment of believers with the same Spirit, God's charge to believers is: "let us do good to everyone, and especially to those who are of the household of faith" (Galatians 6:10). This is the purpose of God's family, "created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that [they] should walk in them." (Ephesians 2:10)

Followers of Jesus Christ or not, we are now living in a time period where we all get to experience the goodness of God. The good we experience may not have anything to do with our faithfulness to God or our relationship with Him.

Do you attribute the goodness in your life to God?

If you are a Christ follower, do you see it as your purpose in life to go about doing all of the good you can?

Bit 4: The intended result of His goodness

“Or despisest thou the riches of his goodness and forbearance and longsuffering; not knowing that the goodness of God leadeth thee to repentance?”

Romans 2:4 KJV

<https://bible.com/bible/1/rom.2.4.KJV>

Why did God create this long time period where He shows us His goodness, despite our open rebellion toward Him and His ways?

He is waiting for everyone to repent, choosing to turn from their life of sin and rebellion against God, to orient themselves to a life of following Jesus Christ, empowered by the Spirit of God that He offers to us, yoked with others that are doing the same.

To repent does not mean to feel sorry for our sin. That's just sorrow, and it will soon pass, most often without life change. To repent means to change our mind, and to change our purpose to align ourselves with the purpose of God for ourselves and the world. It is to reorient ourselves toward a life of obedience to Jesus Christ and to God's Word. It is to truly believe that God and His word are good and true, and act accordingly. It's to demonstrate that our mind is changed by the things we say and the things we choose to do, which show we believe Jesus to be Lord above all.

Repentance is not easy, because it affects our daily lives. It requires denying the self-will that ruled our lives before we chose to allow Christ to take control of us. It requires the death of that old self, in favor of the life that Jesus Christ only offers to those willing to die, or to lose their life as they knew it. There is struggle and there is pain as we put that old person we were to death.

Have you *repented* of your sin, believing in Jesus Christ and His finished work of salvation for you?

If so, Jesus Christ has saved you, and life change will come along with the renewing of Your mind to the Word of God. To have our mind renewed to the mind of the Spirit of God is to not only believe God's word, but to act on it in obedience. This is the commitment we make when in repentance we commit to follow Jesus Christ: to change our mind in order to conform it with His mind. And we keep this commitment, just as a faithful spouse keeps their marriage vows. We keep the orientation toward Jesus Christ until His work in us is complete. We cannot do it alone, so let us only yoke ourselves to brothers and sisters who are on this same journey of following Christ. If you remain faithful, you are on an upward trajectory toward Christlikeness, from one state of glory to another, and more fruit will come, bringing glory to our God as you reflect the glory of His nature more and more.

If not, you are not saved, and you have no part in Christ today. But, God is patient with you, as long as the days of your life.

Bit 5: Now is the favorable time

“Working together with him, then, we appeal to you not to receive the grace of God in vain. For he says, “In a favorable time I listened to you, and in a day of salvation I have helped you.” Behold, now is the favorable time; behold, now is the day of salvation.”

2 Corinthians 6:1-2 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2co.6.1-2.ESV>

If you have not submitted your life to the lordship of God with repentance, God is being gracious to you. He is showing you good will, as He does to all; and merciful kindness, looking to exert influence on you in order to turn you toward a decision to follow Christ for salvation. In the passage above, we are warned not to receive this grace of God in vain. It would be in vain, if you were not to attribute this goodness that you are experiencing to God. It is a great tragedy not to accept the salvation God offers in Christ, available only while the time is favorable. The time is favorable only while you are alive, and you have no idea how long you will live.

If you have submitted your life to the lordship of God, the favorable time you now live in should be treasured as a gift. God is listening to you, and He will reward any step of faith on your part. He will save you and help you, when you trust in His word to do this and rely on Him. His salvation is not a single act, but instead a process in you, whereby He renews your mind to the Word of God, conforming it with His own mind. His salvation is a path that we are set on when we orient ourselves to Him. This is a path of ever increasing faith that leads us on an upward trajectory of Christlikeness. On this path of life, we have the privilege of being co-workers with God, participating in His miraculous work of salvation in the lives of other brothers and sisters. As workers together with Him, God lives in us. He walks in us and helps others through us. He makes us zealous for good works (Titus 2:14), just as He is.

Bit 6: No one is good except God alone

“And as he was setting out on his journey, a man ran up and knelt before him and asked him, “Good Teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?” And Jesus said to him, “Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone.”

Mark 10:17-18 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/mrk.10.17-18.ESV>

Would you describe yourself as a good person, all things considered?

“I’m a good person,” is what most people tell themselves, whoever they are and whatever they have done.

Jesus taught, “No one is good except God alone.” Our Creator, the maker of what is good, decides who can be called good.

We are not good unless God has said we are, and His standard is different than ours. His standard is Himself.

Unless we have been joined to Him, we are not good. Trusting in Jesus Christ is the only way to be joined to God.

Everything God does is good. Everything He makes or remakes is good. If it is right, it is from God. If anything is good in Your life, it is a gift of God.

Do you trust God?

Consider the way you make decisions, including in times of trouble. Do you trust Him above all else?

Trust is God’s main love language.

Bit 7: The favorable time could end at at moment

“The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance. But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the heavenly bodies will be burned up and dissolved, and the earth and the works that are done on it will be exposed.”

2 Peter 3:9-10 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2pe.3.9-10.ESV>

We are not good if we have not been reconnected to God via God’s plan for doing so. His plan is for us to believe the gospel of Jesus Christ and to repent.

To repent is to change our mind and to change the course of our life to become disciples of Jesus Christ. While Christians have belief in Jesus, Christ followers put His word into practice in their daily lives. Only through this radical reorientation are we made right with God and put on a path to be right in our mind. It’s a path that transforms our nature to be like God’s nature, such that, like Christ, we want to: 1) obey God, knowing that obedience to God is “for our good always” (Deuteronomy 6:24) and the good of others, and 2) do good to others.

God is patient with us, waiting for us to come to repentance for a time. God is slow to anger and slow to punish, bearing our mistreatment and offense. It is not God’s purpose or desire that any man or woman should perish, because He is good and is for our good always. God’s hope is that we will come around to recognize His goodness and trust Him so that our relationship with Him can be restored, through His provision of: 1) the gift of His only Son as a sacrifice that cancels the effects of our distrust and rebellion, and 2) the gift of His own Spirit to live in us, empower us, and change us. God’s hope is that we will be obedient to tell others about the provision of the gospel of Jesus Christ so that they too may be saved, for Christ now (almost) only spreads His gospel through His disciples. God is good, and He desires us to be saved “so that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus” (Ephesians 2:7).

Yet, this favorable time where God shows goodness to us could end at any moment. First, there’s our mortality; we could die any day, at any moment. Death can come like a thief. For some, the Lord Jesus Christ will come again during their lifetime, like a thief. Life as we know it will cease, and all of us will be judged by God for what we have done in this life.

Bit 8: The day of vengeance of our God is required by His goodness

“The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me, because the Lord has anointed me to bring good news to the poor; he has sent me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to those who are bound; to proclaim the year of the Lord’s favor, and the day of vengeance of our God; to comfort all who mourn;”

Isaiah 61:1-2 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/isa.61.1-2.ESV>

I don’t like to think about hell, and I wouldn’t want anyone I’ve known personally to go there. But, that doesn’t mean it’s not real.

God has made people to be naturally inclined to believe in the afterlife. We believe that some part of us lives on after death. We have a sense of fairness and justice, and we also tend to adhere to morality.

Scripture teaches that God’s righteous nature and the disobedience of His creation requires judgment, for the one thing our perfect God cannot do is go against His own word. After all, God is not good and loving if He is not just. All is to be made right in the end. If it’s not right yet, it’s not the end.

When Jesus announced the purpose of His ministry at Nazareth, declaring the year of the Lord’s favor (see [Bit 5](#)), He was announcing the fulfillment of God’s prophecy in Isaiah 61. God’s word is unbreakable; it will all be fulfilled in time. In Jesus’ announcement, He stopped short of reading the end of verse 2, “[the Lord God... has sent me... to proclaim...] the day of vengeance of our God,” because Jesus’ first coming was not for this purpose. It was to announce the favorable time we now live in, where God shows us the riches of His goodness, hoping to lead us to repentance.

But the day of vengeance of our God will arrive along with Christ’s second coming, and it will come as a thief. Jesus Christ made God’s standard for judgment clear: “The one who rejects me and does not receive my words has a judge; the word that I have spoken will judge him on the last day. For I have not spoken on my own authority, but the Father who sent me has himself given me a commandment – what to say and what to speak” (John 12:48-49). We will be judged by the words Jesus spoke when He came, as recorded in scripture.

Jesus Christ is no longer in the form of the person that the gospels described, so we should no longer think of Him this way. He has been highly exalted at the right hand of God, given all authority in heaven, on earth and under the earth (Philippians 2:9-10). Even the Apostle John, one of His closest disciples, when he saw the glorified Jesus Christ, “fell at his feet as though dead” (Revelation 1:17).

When we see Him, who knows our every thought, word, and deed, should we not expect to have the same response?

Bit 9: Hell separates those who reject following Jesus from God and His goodness

“And he called out, ‘Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus to dip the end of his finger in water and cool my tongue, for I am in anguish in this flame.’ But Abraham said, ‘Child, remember that you in your lifetime received your good things, and Lazarus in like manner bad things; but now he is comforted here, and you are in anguish. And besides all this, between us and you a great chasm has been fixed, in order that those who would pass from here to you may not be able, and none may cross from there to us.’”

Luke 16:24-26 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/luk.16.24-26.ESV>

Do you believe hell is real?

Do you fear God?

If we choose not to repent and follow Jesus, we trample “underfoot the Son of God” (Hebrews 10:29), and we can expect God’s words to judge us in the end, just as Jesus described in the account of the rich man and Lazarus in the gospel of Luke. In hell, the rich man was told, “you in your lifetime received your good things...”, for our lifetime is the favorable time where God seeks for us to recognize His goodness and trust Him. The rich man did not repent in his lifetime, and so a chasm separated him from God and everything that is of God’s nature, goodness and mercy included.

In the absence of God’s goodness, there is only darkness, affliction, anguish and regret.

The church in this day loves to emphasize the goodness and the love of God, and rightly so. But it is unloving not to speak about the reality of hell that is coming for those who “do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus” (2 Thessalonians 1:8).

We will not be judged according to our good intent, nor our own standard, nor our ideas about what is right and fair. We will all be judged by God’s spoken word.

Bit 10: God's good promise

"And Peter said to them, "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself." And with many other words he bore witness and continued to exhort them, saying, "Save yourselves from this crooked generation.""

Acts 2:38-40 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/act.2.38-40.ESV>

The words above are from the Apostle Peter, declaring that the promise of good in Christ is for all who repent and follow Christ, willing to profess this openly. Two thousand years ago, baptism was an outward, public profession of being a Christ follower, likely to bring persecution by one's family and society. It was the first act of obedience of a disciple, one who puts the words of Christ into practice in their life.

Would you like to follow Jesus for the rest of your life?

Speak your commitment aloud to God. In this decision, the old you dies, crucified with Jesus Christ, and a new, never-before-seen, you is born, identified fully with Jesus Christ in new life. Your dead spirit is made alive in Christ, because you receive the gift of the Holy Spirit to live inside of you; this is the same Spirit that raised Jesus Christ from the dead (Romans 8:11)! You commit to cooperate with the changing work of Christ in you, "to will and to work for his good pleasure" (Philippians 2:13). Nothing will ever be the same. Glory be to God!

If you don't know how to pray to commit the rest of your days to God, say the following prayer out loud and mean it from your heart.

Heavenly Father, I come to You admitting that I am a sinner. Right now, I choose to turn away from sin, and I ask You to cleanse me of all unrighteousness. I believe that Your Son, Jesus, died on the cross to take away my sins. I also believe that He rose again from the dead so that I would be forgiven of my sins and made righteous through faith in Him. I call upon the name of Jesus Christ to be the Savior and Lord of my life. Jesus, I choose to follow You and ask that You fill me with the power of the Holy Spirit. I declare that right now I am a child of God. I am free from sin and full of the righteousness of God. I am saved in Jesus' name. Amen.

Welcome to the family of God! You should now follow in obedience to be baptized. If you don't know where to go to be baptized and to be discipled in following Jesus Christ, please contact me at teams.church@gmail.com.

If you have trusted in Jesus' work for you before, but you have not lived a life in obedience to Jesus' word or have not received God's Holy Spirit, commit yourself fully to God now, receive His Spirit, and believe. God wants all of you – nothing less. Hold nothing back. It's time to live a life in obedience to Jesus' word, empowered by the Spirit of God that lives in you.

Bit 11: God's goodness through Christ

"And you, who were dead in your trespasses and the uncircumcision of your flesh, God made alive together with him, having forgiven us all our trespasses, by canceling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands. This he set aside, nailing it to the cross. He disarmed the rulers and authorities and put them to open shame, by triumphing over them in him."

Colossians 2:13-15 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/col.2.13-15.ESV>

If you have trusted in Jesus Christ and decided to follow Him with your life, God has identified you with Jesus in death, and raised you from death to new life, and life abundant (John 10:10). A record of debt stood against you, but God's goodness in Christ has canceled this record and what it meant for you, nailing it to the cross of Christ.

You are now set free from *anything* associated with sin and death (Romans 8:2), so live now as one who has been set free, knowing that the Spirit of Christ lives in you (Romans 8:9). Stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery (Galatians 5:1). It's time to get clean, and stay clean. You are now a glorious part of the great victory of Jesus Christ over evil, for "greater is he who is in you and he who is in the world" (1 John 4:4). Know that the Almighty God is with you, in you, and for you!

Child of God, you are God's treasure, His glory: "You shall be a crown of beauty in the hand of the Lord, and a royal diadem in the hand of your God" (Isaiah 62:3). You now belong to His family forever, a brother or sister of Jesus Christ, and a co-heir with Jesus Christ (Romans 8:17) of a rich inheritance beyond what you could ask or imagine (Ephesians 3:20).

Because of your repentance and your new position in Christ, God can now be as good to you as He has always wanted to be. As those He has saved from sin and death, God has "seated us with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus, so that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward in Christ Jesus" (Ephesians 2:6-7).

And here is God's good purpose for your life: "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them" (Ephesians 2:10).

He created you to be an ambassador of His goodness – to go about proclaiming the good news of the gospel and doing good. You are now free to be led by God's own character and nature. You are now free to do the will of God, as spelled out in the Bible. Will you obey His word to you today?

As one of God's beloved sons and daughters, having been recreated with His own divine nature (2 Peter 1:4), will you be zealous for good works (Titus 2:14), just as God is? Will you use your freedom to accept responsibility for your fellow man?

Let's not doubt that God is good and that He desires good for you and for His other children.